STELLAMARIS I. AJU

Development Economist

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RESEARCH PROFILE

Development Economics PhD candidate with experience in academic and applied research. Experienced in field experiments across Nigeria, Uganda, Kenya, and international development programmes, mixed-methods data collection, survey programming, econometric analysis, and translating evidence into research outputs.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Development economics; gender and intrahousehold decision-making; agricultural extension; smallholder livelihoods; rural finance; poverty and rural development; climate information services; impact evaluation; behavioural and field experiments.

EDUCATION

PhD in Development Economics | ***Wageningen University & Research (WUR), Netherlands***
01/2023 –01/2027 (Expected)

Projects: Field experiments on agriculture, gender, technology adoption, and farmers' choices in Nigeria; intrahousehold dynamics in Uganda; consumer acceptance of food-safety treatments in Kenya; and menstrual-hygiene product adoption in rural India.

MSc (Cum laude) in Management, Economics and Consumer Studies | ***WUR, Netherlands***
08/2020 - 10/2022

BSc (First Class Honours) in Cooperative Economics and Management | ***Nnamdi Azikiwe University (UNIZIK), Nigeria***
09/2013 - 08/2017

RESEARCH AND TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Doctoral Researcher | ***Development Economics Group, WUR, Netherlands***
01/2023 – Present

- Lead the full research cycle for field experiments and qualitative research with Nigerian smallholder households and agrodealers, including study and instrument design, survey programming, enumerator supervision, field implementation, data quality monitoring, econometric analysis, and reporting.
- Apply mixed methods and Stata/R workflows to agricultural development research conducted with East-West Seed Knowledge Transfer (EWS-KT) and International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI).

Teaching Assistant | ***WUR, Netherlands***
03/2026 - 05/2026

- SDC21306: Methods, Techniques and Data Analysis for Field Research
- DEC23806: Microeconomics for Development.

Visiting Researcher | ***Department of Economics, Carleton University, Canada***
11/2025 - 02/2026

- Conducted full-time research on the Behavioural Economics of Consumer Technology Adoption project, hosted by Professor Vivian Hoffmann, including literature review, data cleaning and analysis, and preparation of research outputs.

Consultant Researcher (Internship and Thesis Research) | ***IFPRI, Kenya***
09/2021 - 11/2022

- Coordinated end-to-end data collection, including instrument design, digital survey programming, enumerator supervision, field implementation, data quality assurance, and reporting.
- Designed behavioural experiments, simulations, quantitative surveys, and qualitative interviews; analysed primary data and supported a cost-benefit analysis framework while engaging the Accelerating Impacts of CGIAR Climate Research for Africa (AICCRA) country teams and other stakeholders.

Graduate Teaching Assistant/Researcher | ***Department of Cooperative Economics and Management, UNIZIK, Nigeria***
05/2019 - 08/2020

- Supported research projects on rural finance and development, including data collection, collation, preparation, and research administration.
- Facilitated lectures in Group Dynamics and Economic Development for classes of up to 250 students.

Undergraduate Research Assistant | ***UNIZIK, Nigeria***
11/2014 - 02/2018

- Assisted with analysis of primary research data and coordinated research and teaching administration.

ADDITIONAL PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Finance Specialist Assistant (Graduate Intern) | ***International Institute of Tropical Agriculture (IITA), Nigeria***
04/2018 - 04/2019

- Supported the Agricultural Transformation Agenda Support Programme, Phase One (ATASP-1), including field research supervision and project finance administration.

PUBLICATIONS AND RESEARCH OUTPUTS

- Galiè, A., Kramer, B., Spielman, D. J., Kawarazuka, N., Rietveld, A. M., & **Aju, S**. (2025). Inclusive and gender-transformative seed systems: Concepts and applications. Agricultural Systems, 226, 104320.
- **Aju, S.**, Kramer, B., & Waithaka, L. (2022). Edutainment, gender and intra-household decision-making in agriculture: A field experiment in Kenya. International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI).
- Timu, A., **Aju, S.**, & Kramer, B. (2021). Toolkit for Cost-Benefit Analysis of Climate Information Services: An outline. AICCRA Info Note. Accelerating Impacts of CGIAR Climate Research for Africa (AICCRA).
- **Aju, S. I.**, & Adeosun, O. T. (2021). Constraints to participation in the management of cooperative societies: Insights for women in Awka community. Journal of Enterprising Communities: People and Places in the Global Economy.
- Adeosun, O. T., Shittu, A. I., & **Aju, S. I.** (2021). Innovation capabilities of women enterprise in informal settings. Journal of Enterprising Communities: People and Places in the Global Economy.

WORKING PAPERS

- **Aju, S.**, ter Steeg, E., Bulte, E., Grimm, M., & van den Berg, M. (2026). Signaling Trustworthiness in Agricultural Input Markets: Experimental Evidence from Nigeria.
- **Aju, S.**, Kramer, B., & van den Berg, M. (2026). Edutainment, Gender, and Intra-household Decision-making in Agriculture: A Field Experiment in Kenya. Manuscript in preparation.
- **Aju, S.**, ter Steeg, E., & van den Berg, M. (2026). Making Expertise Visible: Experimental Evidence from Agricultural Extension in Nigeria.
- ter Steeg, E., **Aju, S.**, & van den Berg, M. (2026). Vegetables as a pathway out of poverty? The adoption and impact of improved varieties and good agricultural practices following market-driven agricultural extension.

CONFERENCES AND WORKSHOPS

1. Nominee, Early Career Speaker | WUR Dies Natalis (2026)
2. Presenter and Poster Session Chair | CGIAR Gender Conference on Accelerating Equality in Food, Land and Water Systems: Driving Solutions through Evidence and Learning (2025)
3. Presenter | Dutch Development Economics PhD Workshop (2025)
4. Break-out Session Co-Host | SeedNL Event: New Frontiers in Seed Sector Development (2023)

AWARDS AND GRANTS

- Wageningen School of Social Science Open Round – Graduate Programme | WUR (2023 – 2027)
- Wageningen School of Social Sciences (WASS) Junior Researcher Grant | WUR (2025)
- Africa Scholarship Programme | WUR (2020 – 2022)

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- Stata, R, Nvivo, Atlas.ti, GAMS, ODK, SurveyCTO, KoboToolbox, LATEX, and Microsoft Office
- Languages: English (C2), Igbo (C2), Dutch (B1).